

NAMES CHANGED, DESTINIES CHANGED

A Devotional Reflection on the Renaming of God's Servants

Rev. Gideon Yegon | Senior Pastor, FPFK Kericho Town Church

REVELATION 2:17

"To the one who is victorious... I will also give that person a white stone with a new name written on it, known only to the one who receives it."

Introduction

Scripture is full of moments where God renames someone at the point of transformation. The new name marks a new identity, a new calling, and a new covenant relationship. What God calls a man or woman often matters more than what they have called themselves. Today we trace this pattern through three towering figures: Jacob, Simon, and Saul.

I. Jacob to Israel

GENESIS 32:22-32

"Your name will no longer be Jacob, but Israel, because you have struggled with God and with humans and have overcome."

Jacob means "deceiver" or "heel-grabber", a name he lived up to from the womb, through the stolen birthright, to years of scheming with Laban. But at Peniel, wrestling through the night with God Himself, he emerges limping yet renamed: Israel, one who struggles with God and prevails. The wound in his hip and the blessing on his life arrive together. God does not erase Jacob's past; He redeems it into a new identity that becomes the name of a nation.

II. Simon to Peter

MATTHEW 16:16-18

"You are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of Hades will not overcome it."

Simon was impulsive and unstable, a man who would later deny Christ three times in a single night. Yet Jesus looks past the failing fisherman and speaks to who he will become: Petros, the rock. The name is prophetic before it is fulfilled. Peter's transformation is not instant; it unfolds through failure, through restoration at the shore of Galilee, and through the fire of Pentecost, until the rock-name finally matches the man.

III. Saul to Paul

ACTS 9:3-6

“Suddenly a light from heaven flashed around him... ‘Saul, Saul, why do you persecute me?’”

Saul was breathing threats against the church when he met the risen Christ on the Damascus road and was struck blind before he could truly see. The shift from Saul to Paul unfolds gradually in the narrative of Acts, but it marks the same pattern as Jacob and Peter: encounter, humbling, and new mission. The chief persecutor of the church becomes its greatest missionary theologian.

The Common Thread

- The old name reflected brokenness, sin, or a smallness of vision.
- The encounter with God involved wrestling, a blinding, or a confrontation — transformation rarely comes painlessly.
- The new name pointed forward to a calling, not merely to a changed feeling.
- God renamed each one before he fully lived up to it — grace precedes performance.

Reflection Questions

1. What name has sin, failure, or circumstance placed on you — and is it the name God is still calling you by?
2. Jacob's renaming came through a night of wrestling. What is the “Peniel moment” God may be inviting you into right now?
3. Peter's rock-name preceded his rock-like character. Where do you need to trust God's word about your future more than your present weakness?
4. Who in your life, like Saul, seems furthest from their calling — and how might you pray for their Damascus road?

Call to Action

Whatever name life, sin, or the enemy has spoken over you — “failure,” “outcast,” “unworthy” — God specializes in renaming His own. He sees not only who you have been but who His covenant purpose is shaping you to become. This week, identify one old name you have carried and exchange it, in prayer, for the name God speaks over you in His Word. Hold on, as Jacob did, until the blessing comes.

Preacher's Note: *This outline may be expanded into a full sermon by developing each renaming episode with its Hebrew/Greek word study (ישראל, עקב, Πέτρος, Παῦλος) and by inviting the congregation forward for a symbolic renaming/anointing moment at the close.*